concluded ahead of time, it became clear that in order to run a complex country like India, rife with various religious beliefs with varying levels of intensity, it was crucial to take all religious leaders into confidence. As mentioned earlier in the book too, some of these relationships that the prime minister has painstakingly built over the years, since his days as Gujarat CM are often on display, whereas at other times, they are more concealed in nature.

17 MARCH 2021

INDIA | 2,52,748 ACTIVE CASES | 1,60,384 DEATHS | 3.06 CRORE VACCINE DOSES

WORLD | 1,44,82,166 ACTIVE CASES | 28,15,397 DEATHS | 25.34 CRORE VACCINE DOSES

The prime minister held a video conference with all the chief ministers alerting them to be vigilant in view of the swiftly rising cases in several districts of the country. Driving the seriousness of the situation, he said, '70 districts of the country have witnessed 150 percent rise in the last few weeks. We need to stop this emerging "second peak" of Corona immediately. If we do not stop this growing pandemic now, then a countrywide outbreak can occur. I urge you all to take quick and decisive steps.'[17] He noted that COVID-19-appropriate behaviour was not being followed and that local and regional governments had gotten negligent in forcing adherence to mask usage. He urged the chief ministers to address these governance problems at regional levels. The fact that we had done reasonably well in combatting the virus up until this point should not turn into slackness. He advised the chief ministers that while the people should not be brought into panic mode, they should incorporate experiences of dealing with the first wave in the strategy of controlling the impending one. He also advised them that special attention should be given to strengthening the 'referral system' to boost contact tracing activities and also the 'ambulance network' should be immediately fortified especially in smaller cities. Raising alarm on the emerging mutants the prime minister said, 'We need to identify emerging mutants and assess their effects in order to appropriately strategize our response.' Before ending his directives to the chief ministers, he expressed concern over high rates of vaccine wastage in some states and asked the CMs to engage with local-level authorities to